

GOVERNMENTS AND POLITICS



A GOVERNMENT IS an institution which makes the political decisions about running a country. Governments and politics are individual to each country because they result from that country's unique history and culture. Yet despite those differences, the systems of government and the issues of political debate are similar everywhere, for they concern how to govern the country best for the benefit of the people.

Types of government

There are almost as many types of government as there are countries in the world. The three main types of government are republican, monarchical, and dictatorial, although these have many variations. Anarchists believe that governments are not necessary.



Republic

Most countries in the world are republics, that is, where electors vote for their head of state as well as for their government. The power of the president ranges from holding real political power, as in the USA, to being a symbolic figurehead, as in India.



The orb symbolizes a monarch's spiritual authority over his or her subjects.



The crown symbolizes sovereignty.

Russian Imperial crown

Monarchy

In a monarchy, the head of the royal family is head of state and is succeeded by his or her closest relative in hereditary succession. In most monarchies, such as Britain or Japan, the monarch has little real power, but in countries such as Morocco, Saudi Arabia, or Jordan, the king holds considerable political power.

Dictatorship

Many countries in the world have at one time or another been ruled by dictators, that is, single rulers with absolute power. Most dictators gain power either through a military take-over or by seizing leadership from an existing ruler, as Saddam Hussain did in Iraq in 1979. Dictators eliminate any opposition to their rule.

Prussian sceptre

The crown jewels (crown, orb, and sceptre) symbolize the monarch's authority.



Democracy

In a democracy, electors vote for a government from a range of political parties. There are two main types of democracy: presidential, where voters elect the president who then runs the government and may choose the prime minister; and parliamentary, where voters directly elect the government of their choice.



Presidential

As the President of Ireland, Mary McAleese (b.1951), is the symbolic head of the nation. In France and Russia, the president chooses the prime minister.

Old Parliament House, Canberra, Australia



Parliamentary

Parliamentary systems exist in both republics and monarchies. Parliament is made up of politicians from different political parties. Electors vote for the party or individual of their choice, and the government is drawn from the largest political party in parliament. The leader of this party becomes head of government. Most nations in the world are parliamentary democracies.

How government works

Each country has its own system of government, usually consisting of four separate parts. The executive governs the country, the legislature makes the laws, the civil service carries out those laws, and the judiciary ensures the laws are applied fairly.

Legislature

The legislature is the place where laws are made and the executive is held to account for its actions in governing. The legislature is made up of elected representatives, and often consists of a lower house of parliament, where laws are made, and an upper house, which keeps a check on the lower house. The British upper house (the House of Lords) is unique in mainly consisting of hereditary, not elected, members.

Parliament House, New Delhi, India



Civil service

The role of the civil, or public, service is to administer the country. Once the executive has proposed a law, and the legislature has passed it, the civil service implements it. Civil servants are non-political and work for whichever government is in power. Their work ranges from local issues, such as street lighting, to national issues, such as defence.



Judge calls court to order with a gavel.

Judiciary

The judiciary makes sure laws are carried out fairly. Judges sit in judgment in individual cases, and also review the operation of the law or suggest changes to improve it. The judiciary is independent from the executive and legislature to maintain its neutrality.

Executive

The executive's role is to govern the country. In parliamentary democracies, the executive consists of senior ministers and the prime minister, who sit in the Houses of Parliament. In the USA, the executive, such as the Secretary of State, Colin Powell (b. 1937), is chosen by the president and is separate from the Houses of Congress.



Pentagon, USA

